

CASE ID: 202101710002

EPISODE NAME: China Retaliates over Hong Kong Sanctions

2021/01/07 - Ongoing

Sender: China (710)

Target: United States (2)

Issue: Retaliation (16)

Final Outcome: Ongoing

Summary:

On 2021/01/07, China threatened the US after an announcement that Washington was considering sanctions on those involved in Hong Kong arrests on 2021/01/06. After the US sanctioned six individuals on 2021/01/15, China imposed sanctions on 28 outgoing Trump officials on 2021/01/20. This episode is ongoing.

Narrative:

On 2021/01/07, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokeswoman Hua Chunying told reporters that the United States would pay a “heavy price” for interference in domestic Chinese affairs.¹ The threat was in response to US Secretary of State Mike Pompeo’s announcement that the US was considering sanctions on those involved in the arrest of Hong Kong protestors on 2021/01/06.²

After the US sanctioned six Chinese officials involved in repressing the Hong Kong protests on 2021/01/15, China responded by imposing travel bans and business activity restrictions on 28 outgoing Trump officials on 2021/01/20.³⁴ The sanctioned individuals included former Secretary of State Michael Pompeo, former trade adviser Peter Navarro, former National Security Adviser Robert O’Brien, former Deputy National Security Adviser Matthew Pottinger, former Health and Human Services Secretary Alex Azar, former Under Secretary of State Keith Krach, former U.S. Ambassador to the United Nations Kelly Craft, former National Security Adviser John Bolton, and former White House strategist Steve Bannon.⁵

This episode is part of a larger campaign of sanctions related to China’s growing control over Hong Kong, beginning on 2019/11/27 when the Hong Kong Human Rights and Democracy Act, which authorizes sanctions on officials responsible for human rights abuses in Hong Kong, was signed into law.⁶ The US and China have continued to trade sanctions over the issue since 2021/01/15.

¹ “China says U.S. will pay 'heavy price' for interference.” *Reuters*, 7 Jan. 2021. <https://www.reuters.com/article/us-hongkong-security-usa-china/china-says-u-s-will-pay-heavy-price-for-interference-idUSKBN29C0SO/?il=0>

² *Ibid.*

³ Pamuk, Humeyra and David Brunnstrom. “U.S. announces new sanctions on six linked to Hong Kong mass arrests.” Yahoo News (Reuters), 15 Jan. 2021. <https://uk.news.yahoo.com/u-announces-sanctions-six-linked-181725391.html>

⁴ Treisman, Rachel. “China Slaps Sanctions On 28 Trump Administration Officials, Including Mike Pompeo.” NPR, 20 Jan. 2021. <https://www.npr.org/2021/01/20/958996415/china-slaps-sanctions-on-28-trump-administration-officials-including-mike-pompeo>

⁵ *Ibid.*

⁶ Cochrane, Emily, Edward Wong and Keith Bradsher. “Trump Signs Hong Kong Democracy Legislation, Angering China.” New York Times, 27 Nov. 2019. <https://www.nytimes.com/2019/11/27/us/politics/trump-hong-kong.html>

These sanctions are still in place, and the episode is ongoing.